
Farmer Recovery: Post-Haying

Specific recovery for the specific damage of
putting up hay

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Introduction

A BETWEEN SESSIONS BONUS PROTOCOL FOR
the hardest two days of the agricultural year.

You just put up hay. Your hands might not even close all the way right now. I know. Let's undo some of this before your body locks up overnight.

Haying season is the hardest thing you can do to a body short of competitive athletics. People who don't farm don't understand. People who do farm don't need an explanation — they know exactly what their forearms feel like at the end of a day of bucking bales.

Most of the farmers on my table in June and July aren't there for a generic "stress massage." They're there because they hayed all weekend and now their hands won't open, their shoulders are screaming, and their low back has gone from compressed to angry.

This protocol is for that window — the first hour after you stop. The recovery work that determines whether tomorrow is "sore but functional" or "I can barely move."

CHAPTER 1

What haying actually does to your body

FOUR SPECIFIC DAMAGE PATTERNS, ALL happening at once:

1. Grip fatigue (forearms and hands)

Bucking bales means gripping twine, lifting, throwing. Your forearm flexors — the muscles that close your fingers — are doing thousands of contractions over the course of the day. They get overloaded, lactate-saturated, and tight. By the end of the day your hands may genuinely not close all the way.

This is also why your fingers feel “stuck” the next morning. The flexors are still locked from yesterday.

2. Shoulder overuse

Throwing bales onto a trailer or up to a hayloft means repeated overhead motion under load. Your rotator cuff, your traps, your deltoids — all working at the limit of their endurance. By the end of the day, the muscles around your shoulder are inflamed and stiff.

3. Low back compression from lifting

Every bale is 40-60 pounds, sometimes more. Lifting them from the ground, twisting to throw them, hundreds of times — your low back takes a beating. Spinal discs compress under repeated load. Sacroiliac joints get jammed. By the end of the day, the low back feels “stuck” and any extension is painful.

4. Hip strain from uneven ground

You’re not lifting on flat gym floors. You’re working on slopes, in fields with tractor ruts, in uneven barn lots. Every step adapts to a different surface. Your hips, especially the small stabilizer muscles, work overtime to keep you upright while you lift. By the end of the day, the deep hip muscles are exhausted and the glutes are fried.

CHAPTER 2

The recovery window — first hour after stopping

THIS MATTERS MORE THAN PEOPLE REALIZE. Your tissue right after physical work is in its most pliable, most responsive state. Blood flow is high, the nervous system is still in motion mode, the muscles are warm.

Wait until the next morning and you're working with cold, stiff, locked-up tissue that's already started laying down adhesions and scar tissue from the day's micro-damage. The stretches are 5x harder. The release takes 3x longer.

Do the recovery work within the first hour. The cost is 10 minutes. The benefit is the difference between being functional tomorrow versus needing a day off.

CHAPTER 3

The 10-minute farmer recovery sequence

YOU CAN DO THIS ON THE TRUCK TAILGATE, ON A barn floor, or in the kitchen. Doesn't matter where. What matters is that you do it.

Step 1 — Forearm release (2 minutes)

Hand and finger work: - Open and close your hands slowly 20 times. If they're seized up, just go through whatever range you have. - Spread fingers wide, then make fists. 10 times. - Roll your forearms on a tennis ball, or use your other hand to massage the meaty part of your inside forearm. 30 seconds each side.

This unlocks the grip-fatigued flexors before they set up overnight.

Step 2 — Shoulder recovery (3 minutes)

Choose one: Hang from a doorframe or pull-up bar for 30 seconds. If you don't have one, do the wall-supported alternative — hands flat on a wall above your head, walk your feet back, let your chest hang down between your arms.

This decompresses the entire shoulder girdle in a way that no stretch can replicate.

Then: - Arm circles, 10 each direction, slow - Cross-body shoulder stretch, 30 seconds each side (pull your right arm across your chest with your left hand, then switch)

Step 3 — Low back release (3 minutes)

Get on the floor (or grass, or wherever — doesn't matter).

- Child's pose: knees wide, sit back on your heels, reach arms forward. Hold 1 minute. Breathe.
- Knees-to-chest: lie on your back, hug both knees in, rock side to side gently. 30 seconds.
- Spinal twist on your back: knees to the right, arms out, look left. Hold 30 seconds. Switch sides.

This decompresses the lumbar spine after the lifting and twisting load.

Step 4 — Hip release (2 minutes)

Standing hip flexor stretch: Step back into a lunge. Squeeze the back-side glute. Push the hip forward. 30 seconds each side.

Figure-four: Cross right ankle over left knee, sit back into a half-squat using a wall or chair for balance. 30 seconds each side. Hits the deep hip muscles that took the brunt of the uneven-ground work.

CHAPTER 4

Beyond the immediate recovery

TWO MORE THINGS THAT MATTER FOR HAYING-season survival:

Hydration + salt

You sweat hard during haying. You lose electrolytes faster than you replace them with plain water. After the day's work, drink a glass of water with a pinch of salt added — not Gatorade, not “electrolyte drinks” with sugar. Plain water with salt. Helps muscle recovery overnight.

Sleep position

Sleep on your back if you can, with a pillow under your knees. Side sleepers — put a pillow between your knees. The goal is to keep your spine in a neutral position overnight so the disc decompression that's supposed to happen during sleep actually happens.

Don't sleep on your stomach. That arches your low back the whole night and undoes any recovery work you did.

CHAPTER 5

Closing

WITHIN AN HOUR OF YOUR LAST BALE. THAT'S the window. Your body is still warm and willing to release. Wait till morning and you're fighting a losing battle.

Haying season is brutal but it doesn't have to break you. Ten minutes of recovery in the right window keeps your body functional through a 6-week run. Skip the window and you'll lose days to stiffness you could have prevented.

Bring this workbook to me on the table after your next big haying weekend. We'll work the deeper layers — but the first-hour recovery is on you.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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